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Modi dispensation as a government of five crorepatris (five chosen industrialists), the party described it as anti-people and declared, "It's time for a change now." In another such ad film by the Congress, the Modi Government has been nailed on the plight of its farmers.

The theme, however, is apt for a party which has been out of power in Gujarat for the past 12 years and is up against a formidable enemy. For the campaign tells party workers that

Government's developmental achievements and his vision of taking Gujarat to new heights. This way, if the negativity in the Congress campaign crosses a certain limit, it might prove to be counter-productive. As a saving grace, the Congress has found an answer to BJP's accusation that it is a new version of the Muslim League. The party plans to fling back BJP veteran L.K. Advani's famous statement describing Muhammad Ali Jinnah as

But things seem to be coming around, thanks to some deft handling by state Congress chief Bharat Solanki, who convinced the disgruntled lot that winning the polls, rather than intra-party relations, was the party's top priority. He earned credibility by setting an example when he kept most of his confidants out of the race for tickets. Significantly, the confidence level within the Congress was not only high, but the party

seemed to be in a combative mood. As Solanki put it: "Modi has made a number of tall claims when it comes to rural development and farmers. If he is so confident on that score, let him fight the election from a rural seat and win. BJP is largely an urban phenomenon and a majority of Gujarat still resides in villages." Counters state BJP chief Purushottam Rupala, "The Congress is living in a world of myth. Narendrabhai's popularity cuts across the entire state. There's no corner from where he can't win with a thumping majority."

Meanwhile, in a move that many would say smacks of pro-Congress bias, the Election Commission has asked BJP to water down a film,

*The Gujarat Miracle: India Tomorrow*, by independent filmmaker Mayank Jain, issuing orders to edit the portions that show Modi's anti-terrorism feat, which portray him as a hero in the backdrop of the UPA Government's failure in handling terror. The film portrays Modi's developmental governance as an ideal model for India as against the "failed Leftist model of West Bengal and the Congress model in Maharashtra". The Hindutva plank helped Modi win the last elections. By converting it into a broader anti-terrorism version, he is aiming for greater resonance rather than just stressing good governance. ■



**THE HOPEFUL:** Senior Congress leader Kapil Sibal (centre) in Gujarat

"nothing is impossible if you are united in your fight and have a precise plan and strategy in place". The Congress gameplan is to cash in on the anti-incumbency factor at grassroots level. Says Siddharth Patel, Congress leader and son of former Gujarat chief minister Chimanbhai Patel, who is involved in drawing up the plan: "We have weaved an emotional campaign that will strike a chord amongst the voters. We are confident of taking our message to the grassroots level." But on the other side, Modi's campaign is largely positive—apart from his barbs, which are part of his Hindutva plank—and talks about his

secular, in response to BJP's attack.

So far, BJP has scored over the Congress. It came out with its first list of 76 MLAs two days before the first Congress list was announced. Though BJP denied tickets to 14 sitting MLAs, besides the 11 rebels, it managed to keep the rebellion under check. The Congress, despite having only 49 MLAs in the state Assembly compared to BJP's 129, struggled to finalise its first list. Its problem stemmed from the fact that in keeping with its plan to ensure that the anti-Modi vote doesn't divide, it had promised seats to both BJP rebels and its ally, the Nationalist Congress Party, triggering rebellion from its own ranks.